International Labour Organization

Think.CareCoop

An orientation on the cooperative business model for the care economy

Training guide

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About Think.CareCoop

Think.CareCoop was developed as an adaptation of Think.COOP, a low-cost, easy to use training tool for those interested in establishing or joining a cooperative. This specific adaptation was done in accordance with ILO COOP and GEDI Units' initiative: Cooperative Care Provision as a Gender-Transformative Decent Work Solution. It draws on technical content from existing ILO materials relating to the care economy as well as cooperative formation and utilizes a peer-learning, activity-based methodology.

Think.CareCoop and Start.CareCoop are aimed primarily at care workers who are interested in understanding how the cooperative model can be used to meet community care needs. Participants may also include individuals from existing institutions and organizations that are interested in adding care services.

Care through cooperatives

Other cooperative enterprises and organizations which provide care as a part of cooperative services

- Education cooperatives
- Financial cooperatives
- Agricultural cooperatives
- Housing cooperatives
- Production cooperatives
- Health cooperatives
- Federations of cooperatives
- Multi-purpose cooperatives

Other institutions and organizations which provide care through a cooperative model

- Trade unions
- Schools
- Community agencies
- Local and federal governments

Care cooperatives

- Domestic worker cooperatives
- Nanny and au-pair cooperatives
- Cooperatives daycares
- Aid and paramedical cooperatives
- Elderly care cooperatives
- Cooperatives for persons with disabilities
- Cooperatives for persons with chronic illness

Peovide direct care as a **side service** to members, beneficiaries and clients

Provide direct care as a **core service** to members, beneficiaries and clients

Care is, "looking after the physical, psychological, emotional and developmental needs of one or more other people, namely the elderly, children, and people living with disabilities, physical illness and/or mental illness."

At the end of this one-day orientation, participants are expected to:

- Understand what a cooperative is (values and principles, differences from other forms of organizations and enterprises etc.)
- Understand how the values and principles of cooperatives can effectively contribute to meeting community care needs.
- Understand the specific benefits and challenges related to cooperative model compared to other types of enterprises or economic organizations, specifically within the care economy; and
- Be able to make an informed and conscious decision of whether a cooperative might be a suitable business option for the participant, both within the care economy and a modality to provide care solutions.

Acknowledgements

Think.CareCOOP was developed collaboratively with the ILO's Cooperative, Social and Solidarity Economy (COOP/SSE) Unit of the Enterprises Department and the ILO's Gender, Equality, Diversity and Inclusion Branch (GEDI). The text was drafted by Mattie Milliken with inputs from Simel Esim, Laura Addati, Mia Touma, Guy Tchami, and Rayann Koudaih.

Sweden
Sverige

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Message to the group

Think.CareCoop was designed for people like you, who are interested in understanding how the cooperative model can serve as a means to providing effective community care services.

During this orientation, you will understand how supportive relationships and cooperation can help you pursue opportunities to improve your livelihood and better respond to care needs. You will learn about the fundamentals of a cooperative business model and understand the conditions under which cooperatives are a pathway to provide care services in your community. At the end of this orientation, you will be better able to decide whether the cooperative model is right for you and your community's care needs.

The style of this training is different from traditional approaches. You will work together as a team to follow the simple step-by-step instructions for discussions and activities in your training guide. A facilitator will be present to assist with any questions on the training content and exercises. Because there is no group leader, all participants who are able should take turns reading the information and instructions out loud to the group and all participants share responsibility for monitoring time. In this new style of training, you will learn from each other by sharing ideas and opinions, skills, knowledge and experience. For this to work, all group members must participate in discussions.

Follow the signs

The instructions in the training guide are easy to follow and the suggested timeframe for each step is provided. Look out for these signs:

This sign indicates the suggested time for the activity

This sign indicates background information to be read to the group

This sign indicates group discussion

This sign indicates that the activity is beginning and that step-by-step instructions need to be read out loud to the group and followed sequentially

The sign indicates a good practice for identifying and meeting the needs of people of different genders (particularly women).

Getting started

Before you begin the training, follow the simple steps below to get organized:

- Organize into small groups of 5-7. The organizers will guide you in how best to do this.
- Identify one group member to volunteer to start the training as "Group Reader". The role of the "Group Reader" is to read the information and activity instructions out loud to the group. Any group member with basic literacy can be the "Group Reader" and you should aim to share this role among group members throughout the training.

All group members are responsible for monitoring time, but one group member should be nominated for each session to remind the group when the suggested time for an activity/ step has been reached. You do not strictly need to follow the suggested timing, but you will need to manage your time for the total training. If one activity lasts longer than the suggested timing, try to save time in other activities to keep the balance.

All group members will receive this training guide. Individual as well as group work can be completed in this guide.

Learning process

Think.CareCoop is a one-day training that consists of 6 sessions (see breakdown below). The estimated total training time is about 7 hours.

Session:	Expected time duration:
SESSION 1: The Who and What of Care	35 minutes
SESSION 2: Good Relationships and Livelihoods	40 minutes
SESSION 3: Horizontal and Vertical Relationships	85 minutes
SESSION 4: The Benefits of Collective Action	55 minutes
SESSION 5: Choosing the Business Structure	120 minutes
SESSION 6: Providing Care Together	75 minutes

Session 1

The Who and What of Care

Session overview

5 minutes

What is care?

Care is a universal need that is fundamental to the well-being of the population and is key to society's reproduction, the workforce and the overall well-being of every individual. More recent conceptualizations of care frame it as a right to care, to be cared for, and to self-care, and extend it to the planet[1]. All human beings are dependent on care, whether paid or unpaid.

Care work broadly consists of activities and relations involved in meeting the physical, psychological and emotional needs of adults and children, old and young, frail and able-bodied. Newborns and young people, older persons, the sick and those with disabilities, and even healthy adults, have physical, psychological, cognitive and emotional needs and require varying degrees of protection, care or support. No matter what you do for a living or where you live, life involves balancing work and care responsibilities.

Care work can be both paid and unpaid is broadly comprised of two kinds of activities:

- **Direct care activities** are face-to-face activities (sometimes referred to as "nurturing" or "relational" care), such as feeding a baby, nursing a sick partner, helping an older person to take a bath, carrying out health check-ups or teaching young children.
- **Indirect care activities** entail cleaning, cooking, doing the laundry and other household maintenance tasks (sometimes referred to as "non-relational care" or "household work"), that provide the preconditions for personal caregiving. These two types of care activities cannot be separated from each other, and they frequently overlap in practice, both in households and in institutions.

The majority of the care work worldwide is undertaken by unpaid caregivers, mostly women and girls from socially disadvantaged groups. While care work can be rewarding, when in excess and when involving a high degree of drudgery, it hampers the economic opportunities and well-being of unpaid caregivers and diminishes their overall enjoyment of human rights.

1 UN Women and ECLAC. November 2021. Towards The Construction of Comprehensive Care Systems In Latin America and the Caribbean: Elements for its Implementation.

Activity 1A: Getting to Know Each Other & Our Care Needs

5 minutes

The goal of this session is to connect with your group members and explore each of your care needs and responsibilities. It is important to learn from and listen to each other as you complete the activities. You should help each other by sharing your different ideas and experiences and ask questions to the group and/or the facilitator if you do not understand a concept or activity. Learning together is a form of cooperation where participants work together to maximize their own and each other's learning.

Whenever people work together for mutual benefit, you have cooperation.

In this activity, you will get to know each other as a first step in building good relationships and cooperation. First, you will read through all the instructions before starting the activity.

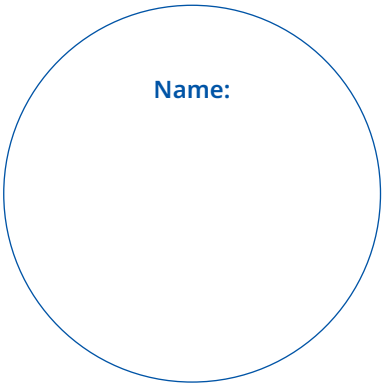
Steps:

25 minutes

1. Write your name in the circle in the worksheet in Activity A.
2. Write down your care needs and care responsibilities
3. Review the lists in the two boxes and circle the individual relationships which are most relevant to your balance of livelihood and family responsibilities (5 minutes)
4. Take turns introducing yourselves in the group by sharing your list (10 minutes)
5. After the introductions, engage in a group discussion to identify commonalities and differences in care needs and responsibilities. Discuss any challenges or unique situations that may impact the balance between livelihood and family responsibilities (10 minutes)

Activity 1A: Worksheet

1.



2. Below is a list of direct and indirect care activities. Which of these do you engage in?

Direct care activities	Indirect care activities
◯ Feeding a baby	◯ Cleaning
◯ Nursing a sick partner	◯ Cooking
◯ Helping an care recipient to take a bath	◯ Doing the laundry
◯ Carrying out health check-ups	◯ Other household maintenance tasks
◯ Teaching young children	

3. Select the individual relationships / communities which are most relevant to your balance of livelihood activities and family responsibilities:

Who supports my care needs?	Who do I provide care for?
◯ Mother	◯ Children
◯ Father	◯ Person with a disability with care or support needs
◯ Husband	◯ Person with a long-term illness with care or support needs
◯ Wife	◯ Mother
◯ Sister	◯ Father
◯ Brother	◯ Spouse
◯ Neighbour	◯ Sibling
◯ Paid care worker	◯ Other relatives
◯ Community member	◯ Neighbours
◯ Association / Cooperative / Self-Help Group / Mutual Association	◯ Other Community members
◯ Faith-community	
◯ Other relatives	

4. Reflect on what is not possible because of your care responsibilities. *For example, you may not able to further your education or enter the formal labour market. Additionally, care recipients may not receiving the highest quality care.*

Session 2

Good Relationships and Livelihoods

Session overview

5 minutes

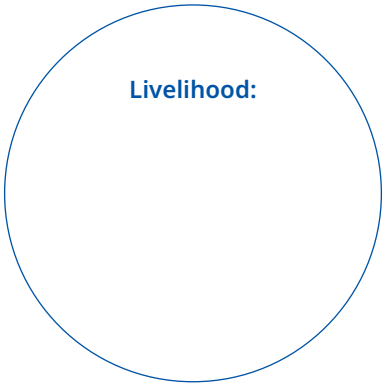
You interact with people every day. No matter what you do for a living or aspire to become, it involves working and interacting with people. In Session 1 you were introduced to the style of training as well as the other participants. In this session, you will get to know each other further and increase your appreciation of the importance of cooperation.

Steps:

15 minutes

1. Write your livelihood in the circle in the worksheet.
2. From the list, encircle the 3 persons (women and/or men) who are helping you the most in the pursuit of your livelihood. These people comprise the 'supportive' or 'good relationships". A relationship is the way in which two or more people are connected and care for each other or the state of being connected, care and cared for. (5 minutes)
3. Share your list with your group members. (10 minutes)

Activity 2A: Supportive Relationships



People who help and support me in my work: (Select 3 people who help you the most)	
◯ Neighbours	◯ Children
◯ Peers – people in the same work as me	◯ People who help me get new customers
◯ Relatives	◯ Suppliers
◯ People who lend me money	◯ Husband/Wife
◯ Siblings	◯ Boss
◯ Parents	◯ Others (specify):
◯ People who work for me	

Think carefully when selecting the 3 persons and think of what they do in their day-to-day. Sometimes the daily activities undertaken by women are taken for granted and are not given their real value, but they are actually key in earning livelihoods. For instance, unpaid care work or domestic chores that are most of the times the primary responsibility of women, may be essential for the family's well-being and livelihood. How have these activities played a role in supporting your work?

Activity 2B: Importance of Relationships

20 minutes

As you have seen from the lists, you need other people to meet your needs in life and you have a responsibility to help meet the needs of others. Relationships based on cooperation, or people working together, keep you happier, healthier and make your work easier to accomplish.

In addition to skills, the cooperation, and relationships you have with your family members, co-workers, peers, and the communities where you are working, caring and living provide the means for achieving your goals. Your relationships give meaning and richness to your work and to your lives. Oftentimes, relationships are key to solving a problem, opening new opportunities and getting the job done.

With good and strong supportive relationships, people have the power to make real change. It does not make sense though to form relationships just to get people to do work for you. People will not respond well, because they will feel used. It is better to form relationships because you genuinely like someone, because you have something to offer to that person, or because you share some common goal(s).

Benefits of cooperation and strong supportive relationships

Cooperation + Strong Supportive Relationships

Open opportunities ▶ Enable you to take on these opportunities ▶ Achieve mutually beneficial results

Now, look again at the list you made. Choose one relationship and share with the group why it is very important especially in relation to your livelihood and care needs.

Important relationship:
This relationship is important because:

Globally, women perform 76.2 per cent of total hours of unpaid care work, more than three times as much as men. Recipients of unpaid care include family members or the wider community members who have care or support needs. Unpaid care work is a key factor in determining both whether women enter into and stay in employment and the quality of jobs they perform.

Session 3

Horizontal and Vertical Relationships

Session overview

5 minutes

Every relationship is different, but they all matter. Care work always takes place within a care relationship, between a caregiver and a care receiver – between mother and child, nurse and patient, domestic worker and client, son and ailing father. We care out of love and affection, duty and responsibility, social and family pressure, and to earn money. A care relationship also has a resource dimension or financial component – someone is incurring costs to provide care. This is evident when there is payment for the caregiver's time and effort, such as salaries for care workers or paid leave for carers. Costs can also be non-monetary, in terms of the opportunities to engage in employment and the types of jobs that unpaid carers are able to access.

Sessions 1-2 should have got you thinking about your care needs and responsibilities, and introduced you to the concept of cooperation. Session 3 will take this further by diving deeper into the importance of relationships. Activity 3A will help you understand the difference between horizontal and vertical relationships. In Activity 3B, you will look into the importance of horizontal relationships in sustaining and improving your livelihoods. You will first read through the instructions before you start working on the activity.

Activity 3A: Identifying Horizontal and Vertical Relationships

10 minutes

Vertical relationships refer to linkages between people performing different functions. In your personal lives, an example of a vertical relationship is between a parent and a child. At work, this can be between an employer and employee.

Horizontal relationships refer to linkages between people performing the same functions. In a family, this may be the relationship between brothers and sisters. While vertical relationships are hierarchical (up down relationships), horizontal relationships involve collaboration and cooperation between and among peers (equal position and social power).

Examples of Vertical Relationships:

Parent	Employer (boss)	Buyer
Child	Employee	Supplier

Examples of Horizontal Relationships:

Husband	Wife
Sibling	Sibling

When workers cooperate with each other for their mutual benefit, they can advocate for better pay, benefits and working conditions. The ILO has identified 5 key recommendations in improving the sharing of unpaid are work and the working conditions in the care sector, known as the "5 Rs for Decent Care Work". This is to **recognize, reduce** and **redistribute** unpaid care work, and to **reward** and **represent** care workers.

Steps:

20 minutes

1. Below is a list of relationships. As each relationship is read, you will discuss whether the relationship is horizontal or vertical. As soon as you agree on the answer, you will shade the appropriate box. (10 minutes)

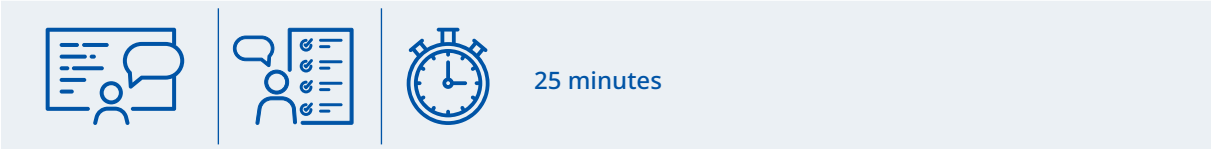
Relationship	Horizontal	Vertical
Producer selling to a trader	○	○
Co-workers helping each other	○	○
A son staying home to provide care to his aging parents	○	○
Neighbors setting up an informal savings / credit scheme	○	○
Childminders providing care for the neighborhood children in their home	○	○
Neighbors building a community water pump	○	○

Answers are on the last page of this training guide

2. You will share one example each of a vertical and horizontal relationship based on your experience or what you have seen in your work or community. Think on relationships you have with both women and men that make it possible to earn your livelihood. (10 minutes)

Vertical Relationship:
Horizontal Relationship:

Activity 3B: Together We Stand, Divided We Fall[2]



Horizontal cooperation lays the groundwork for developing win-win vertical relationships and can help us overcome some of the challenges faced in accessing and/or providing care. For example, when care workers band together, they can form a member-based enterprise where they take turns providing key services to help each other cope with care needs. When people come together, they are stronger and more able to achieve tasks they would ordinarily not be able to do alone.

Mateo is a childcare worker with clients who continually change their schedules making his hours and income inconsistent and unreliable. He wants to work as much as possible to earn a stable income, but is frustrated by the last minute requests and cancellations. Do you think he has leverage to negotiate his own hours with clients? Why or why not?

Now imagine that Mateo joins a business that is jointly owned by childcare workers. The business manages the schedule of all the clients and schedules workers so that they each received a set number of hours (and pay) each week. When there is a scheduling mishap or change, communication goes through the cooperative and workers are still paid their set wages. What benefits does this provide to Mateo? Why?

Steps:

1. Tear the blank page (next page).
2. Fold the paper into two equal halves.
3. Tear the paper from the centrefold. Put the two pieces together into a pile.
4. Repeat the process until the paper can no longer be torn because it is too thick.

The more sheets of paper there are, the more difficult to tear the paper becomes. Similarly, when workers come together they may find that they have more power in negotiating.

2 The exercise was adapted from "Strengthening Leadership in Farmers' Group and Cooperatives: A Training Package" which was commissioned by the Department of Agriculture Marketing and Cooperatives of Bhutan and developed by the Institute for Management Studies with support from SNV Bhutan (2011).

(Paper for Activity 3B: Please tear)

▶ Session 4

The Benefits of Collective Action

Session overview

5 minutes

Different groups of people experience different levels and types of disadvantage, inequality, and discrimination which affects how they provide and receive care. The most frequently excluded workers are self-employed workers in the informal economy, migrants, persons with disabilities, people living with HIV, indigenous people and racialized groups, domestic workers, and LGBTIQ+ persons. These workers can face intersecting forms of disadvantage, inequality and discrimination when they have more than one of these identities.

Collective action refers to action taken together by a group of people whose goal is to enhance their status and achieve a common objective. Whenever people work together for mutual benefit, you have cooperation. The purpose of this session is to help you identify opportunities for group action towards addressing care needs and the conditions where group action may be more beneficial than an individual initiative.

Activity 4A: Opportunities for Group Action

40 minutes

To gain insights on the range of group activities that you can undertake, read the story below.

Maya is a vendor at a local community market and the mother of three children. She brings her children to work each day because they are all not old enough for school and she has no one at home who can help take care of the kids. There are a few day-care centers she has heard of, but all of them are either too expensive or located too far away from her work. She knows it is not ideal to bring her kids to the market where they run around without supervision, but feels she has no other option. Many of the other women vendors at the market do the same.

Recently, there was an accident where a few of the kids were injured as no one was paying close attention to them. This accident has caused Maya to be very stressed and worried and she discussed this with the vendors surrounding her stall. They know that most of the women at the market are in the same situation as Maya and believe that there has to be a solution that can work for them all. After discussing, they had the idea to start a childcare group in which all of the mothers pool their resources, making things more convenient and affordable.

By coming together, they are each able to create a schedule in which they take turns providing childcare while no one misses a day of wages. They also have the ease of bringing their children to the market while knowing that they are safe and taken care of instead of just running around. Eventually the childcare cooperative is so successful, they are able to hire a few of the women to work full time. This system allows each of the women to focus on their work while trusting that their children are safe and taken care of.

Maya's Constraints	**Solution/Group Action**	**How may this help Maya?**	**How may this help the wider community?** (create jobs, improve safety / health of children, etc)

Activity 4B: Helping Myself, Helping Others

30 minutes

Here are key guidelines for when you should consider group action to solve a problem or take advantage of an opportunity:

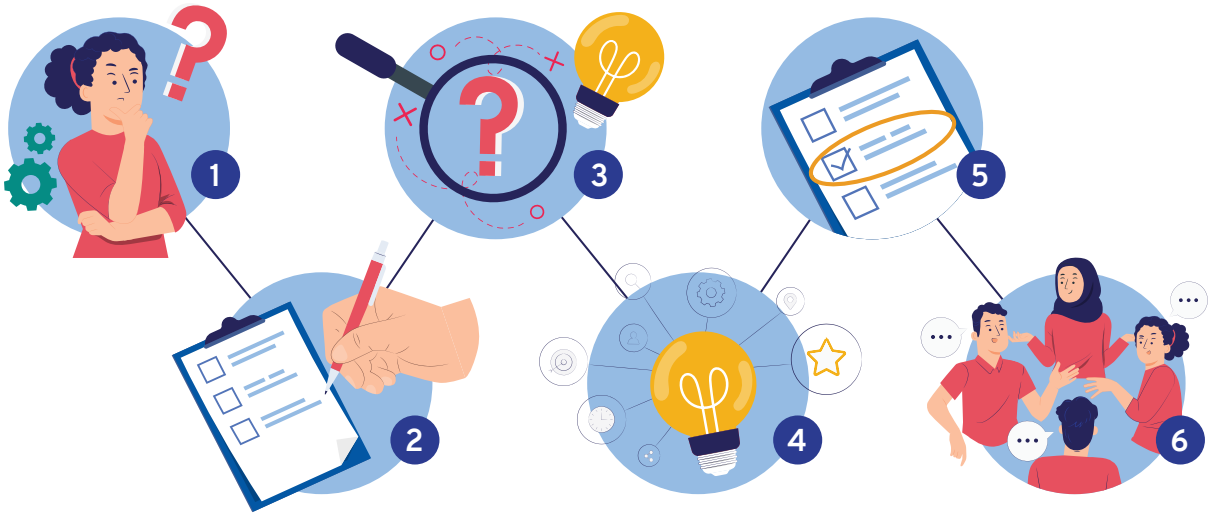
- **The resources or services you need are more than what you can individually afford.**
  Maya and her group all needed childcare near their workplace but individually they could not afford to hire someone. They pooled their money and arranged a schedule so that each member could contribute to and benefit from the services provided.
- **You want to reduce costs of supplies or services by buying in bulk to get a discount.**
  By pursuing childcare services together rather than individually, Maya and her group were able to achieve services that better fit their needs and at a more affordable cost.
- **You want access to a wide range of services to improve skills and knowledge as well as acquire the resources (e.g. finance, equipment, etc.) to grow your business.**
  Maya and her group are now able to secure a loan from a microfinance institution because extension agencies and microfinance institutions are often willing to serve groups, but not individuals.
- **You need to increase your bargaining power.**
  Horizontal cooperation makes it possible to negotiate, demand services, and influence desired changes in policies. Through collective action Maya and her group can attract new customers and negotiate better prices.

The steps below will guide you through the constraints and/or opportunities you face yourselves in your work, livelihood and home life. You will then determine the advantages of addressing these individually or through group action.

Steps:

1. Review the example of the Stockholm Cooperative for Independent Living[3] and understand the constraints, solutions and value additions listed in the table below.
2. Next, list down at least 3 constraints you face in your work, business or livelihood due to care responsibilities.
3. Identify possible solutions to your constraints. Remember that when you address your constraints with sustainable solutions, you are creating opportunities for improvement for yourself and others.
4. Determine the advantages of undertaking the solution individually or through group action. Keep the guidelines in mind to help you decide.
5. Identify which option (individual or group action) is a better option for you.
6. Share and discuss with the group

3 Case study developed from the Independent Living Institute (ILI), a policy development center specializing in consumer-driven policies for disabled peoples' freedom of choice, self-determination, self-respect and dignity. More resources can be found at their website: https://www.independentliving.org/



Transforming Constraints into Opportunities

The Stockholm Cooperative for Independent Living is a pioneering model that aims to empower people with disabilities to live independently and participate fully in society. Founded in Stockholm, Sweden, this organization is user-led, meaning it is run and governed primarily by individuals with disabilities themselves. The organization provides a range of support services tailored to the specific needs and preferences of its members, which include people with physical, sensory, and cognitive disabilities.

One of the key aspects of this program's success is the shift from the traditional medical model of disability to a social model that focuses on removing barriers and creating an inclusive environment. People with disabilities are enabled to lead independent lives, pursue education, employment, and social activities, and advocate for their rights and dignity in society. The Stockholm Cooperative for Independent Living cooperative model serves as an inspiring example of how people with disabilities can come together to transform their lives and the broader community through collaboration and empowerment.

Activity 4B: Example

Constraints:	▶ Lack of support for independent living for people with disabilities. ▶ Limited access to tailored services and resources. ▶ Social exclusion and marginalization of individuals with disabilities. ▶ Traditional medical model of disability focusing on limitations rather than empowerment. ▶ Limited decision-making power for people with disabilities in their support services. ▶ Community care work perceived as "help" and not professional work.
Solutions:	▶ User-led approach: The cooperative model is governed and managed primarily by people with disabilities, giving them a strong voice in decision-making. ▶ Tailored services: SCIL provides personalized support services to meet the diverse needs and preferences of its members. ▶ Social model of disability: The cooperative adopts a social model, emphasizing the removal of barriers and creating an inclusive environment. ▶ Self-help and mutual support: Members support each other, fostering a sense of community and belonging. ▶ Advocacy: SCIL empowers its members to advocate for their rights and dignity in society.
Value additions:	▶ **Independent living:** The model enables people with disabilities to lead independent lives, experience decent work, and make choices about their support services. ▶ **Social integration:** Members participate fully in society, breaking down barriers and combating social exclusion. ▶ **Empowerment:** People with disabilities gain confidence, skills, and self-determination through active involvement in the cooperative. ▶ **Tailored support:** SCIL's personalized services cater to individual needs, ensuring a higher quality of life for its members. ▶ **Collective impact:** By working together, members have a stronger voice, making a positive impact on disability rights and services in the community.

Activity 4B: Worksheet

Constraints you are Facing:	Possible Solution	Advantages of Group / Individual Action:	Which option is better?

Session 5

Choosing the Business Structure

Session overview

5 minutes

Many times, small groups of individuals or friends come together informally to share resources, support each other in finding work or selling their products/services together to save on costs and get a higher price. Informal enterprises face limitations such as lack of legal form to transact with banks and institutional buyers (e.g. supermarkets), workers not enjoying employment benefits, loose commitments and obligations among participating individuals, etc.

As these informal groups meet and work together more regularly, they may want to transform it into a formal organization in order to have legal status, access loans from banks, and benefit from other protections such as health insurance and social protection. In moving from informal collaboration to formal businesses, you have an important choice to make regarding the ownership and structure of your business. In Activity 5A you will look at the different business structures. Activity 5B will walk you through the factors to consider when choosing a business structure. In Activity 5C you will look into the principles of a cooperative and assess whether these are aligned with your own aspirations.

Activity 5A: Understanding Business Structures[4]

40 minutes

A business may be owned and managed by a single individual or a group of individuals. Such arrangement of ownership and management is termed as business structure. The business structure influences everything from day-to-day operations to the capital that one needs to personally raise, personal liability, and taxes. To gain an understanding of the common business structures, perform the steps as they are read. It should be noted that allowed business legal structures vary from country to country.

Steps:

1. Take turns in reading aloud the descriptions of each business structure. After each description is read, identify two to three businesses in your area that fit the description. (15 minutes)

Individual proprietorship

- Single ownership
- Owner provides labour, capital, and management
- Entitled to all profits; liable for all losses
- Objective: Earn income and be one's own boss
- Examples: Mostly small businesses

Businesses in your area that fit this description:

Investor-oriented corporation

- A way to raise large amounts of capital
- Ownership share and control depend on amount invested
- Owners only provide capital
- Objective: Earn a return on invested capital
- Examples: Most medium and large businesses

Businesses in your area that fit this description:

4 There are different types of business structures depending on the country. You may ask the facilitator for additional information on business structures allowed in your country.

Company limited by guarantee

- Initial funding raised through grants and donations
- Has no share capital or shareholders, but instead has members who act as guarantors. The guarantors agree to contribute a sum of money (typically very small) which will be collected in case the company faces financial difficulties.
- The financial liability of members is limited to committed guarantee.
- Members do not earn profit; profit is reinvested into the company
- Objective: Support company's advocacies rather than benefit financially
- Examples: Non-profit organizations, charity organizations

Businesses in your area that fit this description:

Cooperatives and other sse entities

- Owned, managed, and controlled by members
- A way to provide "service at cost" to groups of individuals and/or firms
- Members/owners/patrons provide capital and oversight control
- One member, one vote
- Objective: Provide services with members getting back part of the profit from their own purchases
- Examples: multistakeholder cooperative, worker cooperative, vendor cooperative

Businesses in your area that fit this description:

2. Individually read the stories and identify the type of business structure. Discuss and compare your answers with your peers. (20 minutes)

Ana runs a daycare center in her village. She established the center five years ago with an initial investment of US$300, which she borrowed from the financial cooperative she is a member of. Ana's daycare center provides a safe and nurturing environment for children, allowing parents in the village to work or attend to other responsibilities while knowing their children are well-cared for. Over time, Ana's business has grown successfully, and she has been able to repay the borrowed money.

Business structure:

Daniel owns a network of assisted living facilities with 20 other individuals who share the vision of providing quality care for older persons. They collectively established the first facility by each contributing an investment of US$100. Daniel's ownership grants him the right to vote for the board of directors and participate in important decision-making processes related to policies and governance. The business structure ensures that all owners have equal voting power, regardless of their investment amounts. At the end of each year, Daniel receives a share of the profit proportionate to his investment, acknowledging the value she has contributed to the business.

Business structure:

Gabriela and Marcus are shareholders in a company that operates a network of medical clinics. Together with three other shareholders, they have collectively invested in the business to provide accessible healthcare services to the community. Gabriela has 50% share of the company. In other words, she provided 50% of the capital. The remaining 50% is shared by the four other shareholders with Marcus accounting for 20%. Since Gabriela has the largest share, her opinion and vote matter most. At the end of each year, Gabriela gets 50% of the profit that the business has decided to distribute to shareholders. Gabriela likes this structure because it enables her to proportionately earn from her investment and, at the same time, her personnel assets are not at stake.

Business structure:

Thirty small-scale healthcare providers join forces to establish XYZ Healthcare Services, a shared facility that offers comprehensive healthcare services. They secure a location where all members can provide their services, such as medical consultations, diagnostic tests, and therapy sessions. Each member contributes a small sum of money which will be collected in case the company faces financial difficulties. While the members do not receive individual shares in the profits generated, they benefit from shared resources, reduced costs, and collective marketing efforts. Additionally, the structure ensures that the members support one another in case of financial challenges by pledging a certain funds collectively, reflecting their commitment to providing essential care to the community.

Business structure:

Answers are on the last page of this training guide

3. Of the four types of business structure described in Step 2, which do you think is best suited for care provision and why? Discuss your answer with your group members. (10 minutes)

Activity 5B: Factors to Consider

30 minutes

In choosing the organizational structure, the following are the key factors to consider:

a) Motivation for setting up: What challenges, issues, or problems are you trying to resolve? What do you expect to get from this enterprise?

b) Ownership: Will you be working alone, or will there be multiple owners?

c) Participation and control: Who participates in management and policy decisions?

d) Profit sharing: How will the profits of the enterprise be shared?

e) Resources: What is your ability to acquire resources such as land, working capital, building, facilities, etc.?

f) Liability: To what extent would you want to be personally liable for the debts of the business?

When making your choice on the structure, make sure that you highlight what is most important to you and your plans for the future. Remember though that not one single type of ownership may give you all the features you desire. Your task is to decide which type of entity offers the features that are most important to you.

Steps:

1. Individually, read the question in Column 1. Choose and circle the answer (Columns 2 to 5) that is closest to what you feel and think is the best for you. (10 minutes)

Question Column 1	**Choose and encircle your answer**			
	Answer 1 Column 2	**Answer 2** Column 3	**Answer 3** Column 4	**Answer 4** Column 5
What is your main objective for setting up the business?	Earn profit for myself	Earn profit equivalent to my investment	Access services that would help me and my peers improve our livelihood while also earning surplus/profit as additional income	Access services that would help me and my peers improve our livelihood; support an advocacy
How much control do you want in running the business ?	100% control	Control based on investment	Equal control for all members with shares	Equal control for all members

Question Column 1	**Choose and encircle your answer**			
	Answer 1 Column 2	**Answer 2** Column 3	**Answer 3** Column 4	**Answer 4** Column 5
How do you want profits to be shared?	100% profit to person who provided the capital.	Profit shared according to investment.	Profit shared based on use of service or in proportion to the business I conducted with the enterprise.	Profit not distributed among the members but reinvested into the business.
Do you have all the skills and resources to run the business?	I have the resources and skills to set-up and run the business. I can also hire workers and get a loan whenever necessary.	No but the shareholders will provide the capital to secure all skills and resources needed.	No and I do not have the capacity to hire employees and get a loan.	No and I do not have the capacity to hire employees and get a loan.
How much liability exposure are you willing to take?	I am willing to accept all responsibility for debts, losses, and other liabilities.	I am not willing to put my personal assets, not connected to the business, at risk.	I am not willing to put my personal assets, not connected to the business, at risk.	I commit to give the amount (nominal) I pledged when I became a member in case the business gets into financial problems.

2. Which column of answers describes: (5 minutes)

a) A cooperative?
b) An individual proprietorship?
c) An investor-oriented corporation?
d) A company limited by guarantee?

Answers are on the last page of this training guide

3. Javier's father is growing older and needs support to get through each day. Javier and his wife both work full time and their kids are in school. The cost of private care is very expensive and there are no public support systems in place. Javier worries about how lonely his father will be and wants him to enjoy this season of his life. Javier has recently discussed this challenge with some of his neighbours only to realize that this is a very common experience for people her age. Javier and his neighbours are thinking of coming together to form an organization in which the older people in their community can spend time together and get the support they need. The group believes that if they can present themselves as an enterprise or cooperative, they can negotiate directly care workers to pay a competitive rate for high quality services that match their needs.

   a) If you were one of Javier's friends, which type of business structure would you choose?
   b) Review your answer in Step 1 and use this as your basis in choosing the business structure. (5 minutes)

Proposed enterprise _____

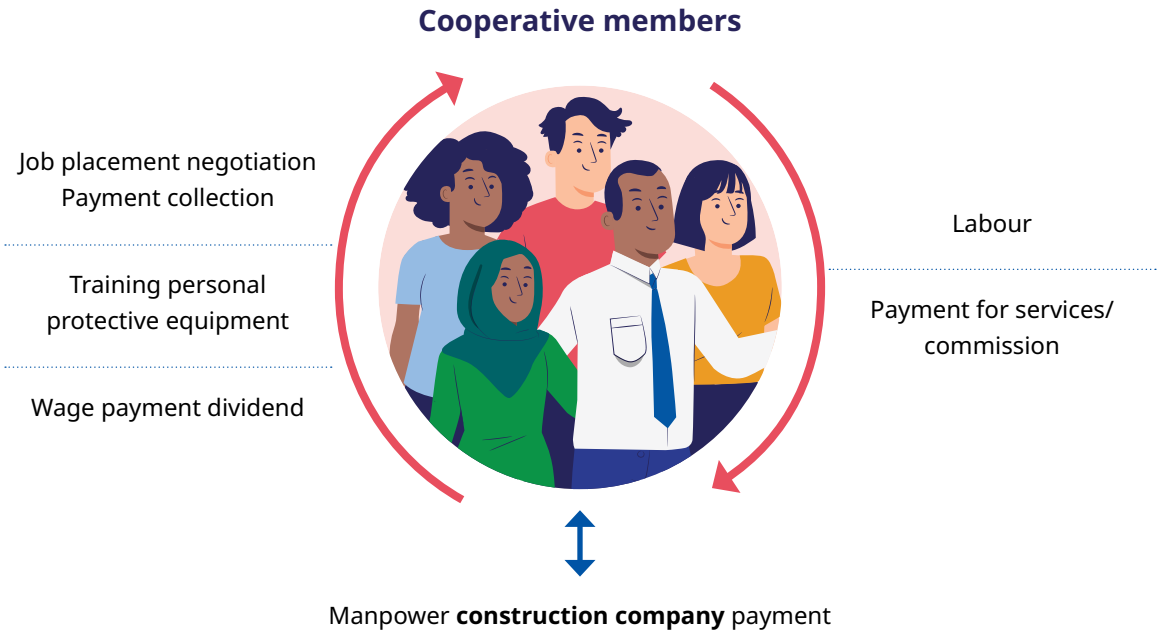
Activity 5C: Principles of a Cooperative

15 minutes

Cooperatives are businesses owned by women and men members to meet their mutual needs. Regardless of the goods and services provided, cooperatives contain the following elements:

- Cooperatives are businesses
- Cooperatives are owned and controlled by those who use their services (the members)
- Cooperatives are democratically governed
- Cooperatives exist to serve their members

Cooperatives are included in the **Social and Solidarity Economy**, along with associations, mutual societies, foundations, social enterprises, self-help groups and other entities engaged in economic, social, and environmental activities to serve the collective and/or general interest, which are based on the principles of voluntary cooperation and mutual aid, democratic and/or participatory governance, autonomy and independence, and the primacy of people and social purpose over capital. This training focuses on cooperatives but depending on your context another SSE model may be more suitable.



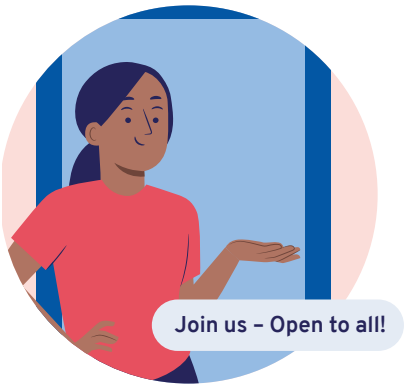
It is important that the cooperative reflects the particular interests, needs and contributions of the different genders represented. You may need to take into account particular situations that women face such as legislation that does not allow them to own land or be economically independent, gender norms that women are responsible to undertake care responsibilities, discrimination due to pregnancy, etc. More specific strategies to ensure women members' active participation in the cooperative will be provided in Start.CareCoop.

Steps:

30 minutes

1. First, you will look more closely into the seven principles that guide or govern the establishment and operations of a cooperative and assess their relevance to your own goals and objectives particularly with regards to your livelihoods. Note that the principles are descriptive of what a cooperative should be rather than prescriptive.

Principle 1. Voluntary and Open Membership



Cooperatives are voluntary organizations, open to all people able to use its services and willing to accept the responsibilities of membership, without discrimination based on gender, social status, racial group, political or religious views, HIV status, disability, migration status, or other forms of marginalization. Members may also withdraw whenever they wish.

Which of the actions below is a violation of the principle above?

a) Practices are free from discrimination.
b) Removes physical and procedural barriers that limit members' access to services.
c) Harasses members who want to terminate their membership.
d) Open to all individuals interested in joining the cooperative.

Principle 2. Democratic Member Control

Each member has equal voting and decision-making power in the governance of the cooperative. Each member gets one vote, regardless of the level of her or his investment in the cooperative. Individuals serving as elected representatives are accountable to the membership. Which of the actions below is a violation of the principle above?

a) Only invites to meetings the members who always agree to the proposals of the President.
b) Honours equal voting rights for all.
c) Open in sharing information to all members.
d) Encourages all members to give their feedback on the services of the cooperative

Principle 3. Member Economic Participation

Members provide the money and/or resources needed to start and operate the business. Decisions on how the funds of the cooperative will be used are made democratically and not based on the amount invested. The benefits that members get from the cooperative are in proportion to the business they conduct with the cooperative rather than on the capital invested. Which of the actions below is a violation of the principle above?

a) Allows members to contribute fairly to the cooperative's capital.
b) The use of capital and funds is decided by those who have provided the larger chunk of working capital.
c) Allocates surpluses equitably for all members.
d) Utilizes capital to achieve cooperative's long-term goals.

Principle 4. Autonomy and Independence

Cooperatives are autonomous, self-help organizations controlled by their members. If they enter into agreements with other organizations, including governments, or raise external capital, they do so on terms that ensure democratic control by members and maintain their autonomy. Which of the actions below is a violation of the principle?

a) To the extent possible, the cooperative follows the "wishes" of the politicians to gain their favour even if it is detrimental to the interest of the majority of members.
b) Enters arrangements with governments or other organizations only when terms respect the cooperative's autonomy.
c) Acts as independent organization through members' control.
d) Uses independence as a differentiating factor in the market.

Principle 5. Education, Training, and Information

Cooperatives provide education and training for their members, elected representatives, managers, and employees so they can contribute effectively to the development of their cooperatives. They inform the general public – particularly young people and opinion leaders – about the nature and benefits of cooperation. Which of the action below is a violation of the principle?

a) Provides training and education to allow members and employees to perform their responsibilities satisfactorily and to promote active participation in the cooperative.
b) Conducts awareness campaigns on the benefits of cooperation / the cooperative model.
c) Enhances knowledge of members on the cooperative business model.
d) Only board members and the manager are provided opportunities to participate in training.

Principle 6. Cooperation among Cooperatives

Cooperatives serve their members most effectively and strengthen the cooperative movement by working together through local, national, regional and international structures. Which of the actions below is a violation of the principle?

a) Builds relationships with local cooperatives to protect local economies and create increased member value.
b) Avoids sharing information and working with cooperatives perceived to be competitors.
c) Participates in cooperative knowledge sharing events.
d) Learns from other cooperatives.

Principle 7. Concern for the Community

Cooperatives work for the sustainable development of their communities through policies and actions approved by their members. Which of the actions below is a violation of the principle?

a) Treats all people with respect and dignity.
b) Utilizes local resources and skills.
c) Implements community programs that benefit members and the community.
d) No conscious consideration on environmental impact as biodiversity conservation is not among its focus.

2. Assess the importance of each principle in your choice of an organization to help you improve your livelihood and meet your care needs. Rate each of the principles using the scale: (5 minutes)

1 = Not at all important 2 = Not very important 3 = Somewhat important
4 = Very important 5 = Extremely important

Principle	Rating
Voluntary and open membership	
Democratic member control	
Member economic participation	
Autonomy and independence	
Education, training, and information	
Cooperation among cooperatives	
Concern for the community	

3. Based on your rating, select the most important principle for you and discuss with the group why you consider it very important. (10 minutes)

Most important principle:
It is important because:

Session 6

Providing Care Together

Session overview

15 minutes

In Activity 6A, you will look into the different types of cooperatives and the range of services offered by a cooperative. You will end this module by listing the advantages and disadvantages of a cooperative. This will help you further decide whether the cooperative is the right business model to respond to your needs and aspirations.

Activity 6A: Types of Cooperatives & Range of Services

Products and services offered by cooperatives depend on the needs of their members, users and the local context in which they are operating. In many cases, the activities of cooperatives are aimed at addressing constraints that members face (such as unpaid care responsibilities) and/or helping them take advantage of opportunities that they could not possibly do so on their own.

The table below shows the most common care cooperative models.

Type:	Description:
User cooperative	User cooperatives are owned by their members who are users of the cooperatives' services. Examples include senior or persons with disabilities housing cooperatives, parents' childcare cooperatives, or older persons care provided by consumer cooperatives.
Worker cooperative	Worker cooperatives are **jointly-owned, operated and governed** by their worker-members. In the care sector, worker cooperatives are found in childcare, home-based care, and domestic work, among others, in which the workers are both **employed by and jointly-own** the cooperative.
Multi-stakeholder cooperative	Multi-stakeholder cooperatives bring together numerous stakeholders involved in the provision of care services. Stakeholders may include beneficiaries and their families, care workers, other community members and government representatives, among others. Examples include: older persons care cooperatives with diverse services and certain types of health care cooperatives. The multi-stakeholder model is a unique characteristic of cooperatives that provide care.
Other	As care needs continue to increase globally, many existing (non-care) cooperatives may consider adding care services in order to better meet their members' needs.

To better understand and appreciate the services of cooperatives meeting care needs, follow the steps below.

Steps:

45 minutes

1. As each example is read, identify as a group: the type of cooperative, the services provided by the cooperative, and the benefit/s derived by the members. (25 minutes)

Example 1
HealthCare Heroes In this cooperative, healthcare professionals such as nurses, therapists, and support staff come together to jointly own and operate a home healthcare agency. The cooperative model allows the workers to have a say in decision-making, share profits, and collectively contribute to creating a positive working environment. HealthCare Heroes Cooperative focuses on providing in-home care services, ensuring that the workers are directly involved in the planning and delivery of care.
Type of cooperative:
Services provided by the cooperative:
Benefits received by members:

Example 2
ElderConnect ElderConnect Cooperative Care is a cooperative where older persons and their families collectively own and manage a community-based care service. Members have a direct stake in the cooperative and participate in decision-making processes. The cooperative ensures that the care services provided are tailored to the specific needs and preferences of the older members, fostering a sense of community and shared responsibility for the well-being of its users.
Type of cooperative:
Services provided by the cooperative:
Benefits received by members:

Example 3

CommunityCare Alliance

In the CommunityCare Alliance Cooperative, a collaborative effort is made among workers, users (patients and their families), and local healthcare organizations to care for people with HIV/AIDS. This cooperative structure underscores the importance of community involvement and diverse stakeholder engagement in shaping and delivering comprehensive care services including prevention, treatment, and support. The name "CommunityCare Alliance" highlights the cooperative's commitment to a unified approach that considers the needs and perspectives of all stakeholders.

Type of cooperative:
Services provided by the cooperative:
Benefits received by members:

2. Below is a list of various types of care cooperatives and an example of how they can help meet your needs. Which of these cooperatives do you think would be most relevant to the people in your community? (5 minutes)

   - ◯ Childcare cooperative such as day care center, after-school care, home-based care.
   - ◯ Cooperative for older persons, providing services such as home-based care, cooperative housing, or recreational center to meet diverse health and social needs, including housing, physical and mental health concerns, and social integration. Rather than prioritize treatment of illness, these types of cooperatives emphasize older persons' decision-making processes related to their well-being.
   - ◯ Cooperative serving persons with disabilities (children, adults or both), providing services to persons with both physical and developmental disabilities. Services are broad and range from physical care and rehabilitation to social services (such as job preparation in and beyond the cooperative), as well as life skills training and independent living.
   - ◯ Cooperatives serving persons living with illness or disease provide physical services, such as homebased or clinic-based health services and care, as well as social and support services to beneficiaries and their families.
   - ◯ Existing cooperative (outside the care economy such as agricultural) providing care services for members.
   - ◯ Others (specify) _____

3. As you have seen in the various examples presented here, groups of people can set up cooperatives to meet their care needs. In turn, this helps formalize, reduce and redistribute unpaid care work which is often performed by women.

   Cooperatives can help you do things you cannot do by yourselves. If you were to join or form a cooperative, what would be the main services that you would be needing? (Think back to Session 1). What benefits do you expect to receive from a cooperative? Fill out the table below and share your answer with the group. (10 minutes)

Services I need:	Benefits I expect:

Activity 6B: Advantages and Disadvantages of a Care Cooperative

15 minutes

You have learned in the previous sessions that cooperatives have a dual nature; as business enterprises on the one hand, and as membership-based associations organized for collective action on the other. The basic difference between a traditional business and a cooperative is that a cooperative is collectively and democratically owned and controlled by the people using its services or products, while in a traditional business one person or group of persons make most of the decisions. In traditional businesses, customers are external to the company. In cooperatives, the owners and the users or customers are the members.

In a care cooperative, people come together to address their care needs and therefore, profit generation is not the only or primary objective. This is what makes cooperatives and other SSE entities different from traditional corporations where maximizing shareholder value is primary focus. In the case of cooperatives, the owners are the same people who are operating the organization and the main goal is to benefit each member equally. This does not mean, however, that corporations are bad and cooperatives are good. It depends mainly on the conditions and objectives of the people who are setting up the business.

The formation of cooperatives or membership in cooperatives is most likely to be beneficial under the following conditions:

a) Problems and constraints cannot be solved individually or adequately. The problem can be better solved by collaborating with people who face the same problem.

b) Assistance needed to address the problem cannot be easily or satisfactorily accessed from family, other enter- prises, government, and other social institutions. Cooperative is the most promising provider of the solution needed.

c) The advantages of membership (access to services, inputs, financial services, markets, etc.) out- weigh the duties of membership (contribution of resources such as money, time, skills, etc.).

Women-only cooperatives are established to better address women's needs, concerns and contributions, especially in cultural contexts where men and women do not mix with each other to start a business.

Steps:

20 minutes

1. List down the advantages and disadvantages of forming or joining a cooperative from your own perspective and given the current conditions you face in your work or livelihood. (10 minutes)

Advantages of Joining/Forming a Cooperative that meets care needs	Disadvantages of Joining/Forming a Cooperative that meets care needs

2. After a thorough analysis, do you think the cooperative is an appropriate model for your care needs? Why or why not? (10 minutes)

Answers

Activity 3A

Farmer selling to a trader	Vertical
Workers helping each other	Horizontal
A shop owner consulting a peer regarding a new technology	
Neighbors setting up an informal savings / credit scheme	Horizontal
Neighbors building a community water pump	Horizontal
Parents paying for childcare services	Vertical

Activity 5A

a) Individual Proprietorship
b) Cooperative
c) Investor-oriented corporation
d) Company limited by guarantee

Activity 5B

a) Column 4
b) Column 2
c) Column 3
d) Column 5

Activity 5C

Principle 1	C
Principle 2	B
Principle 3	A
Principle 4	A
Principle 5	D
Principle 6	B
Principle 7	D

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